

Question: Answer one of the questions using one of the workable ethical theories covered in class (Kantianism, utilitarianism, social contract theory or virtue ethics); make sure that your choice is clearly stated in the essay:

1. Suppose a student feels unfairly graded by their peers in a course dependent on peer grades, and has found a security flaw that allows them to alter their own grades without being caught. Is it morally justifiable for the student to exploit this flaw?
2. A nurse's close friend is in desperate need of medical help but cannot afford treatment. Is it morally justifiable for the nurse to falsify medical documents to help their friend, even though it violates their professional duties?
3. Suppose a society holds that it is wrong for one individual to eavesdrop on the telephone call of another citizen. Should that society also prohibit the government from listening in on its citizen's telephone calls?

Answer:

Rule utilitarianism is an ethical framework that creates and evaluates general rules based on their net overall consequences. According to rule utilitarianism, a student exploiting a security flaw to modify their own grades is morally unjustifiable.

The general rule permits grade alteration which would strip the grading system's integrity, resulting in an overall negative outcome due to collateral impact. According to George Akerlof's "Market for Lemons" model, buyers cannot trust cars they are purchasing if bad ones are indistinguishable from the good, resulting in a loss of market credibility. Similarly, once self-determined grade changes are widely adopted causing skewed grading distributions, academic aptitude would be indistinguishable between students. This would negatively impact future employers who are unable to gauge talent and thus unknowingly hire unqualified students. This would also impact other students deserving of professional opportunities who no longer stand out while only benefiting individuals who would have otherwise fallen below the average.

One may argue that if it's only students that have been unfairly graded that alter their grades, this would result in a positive outcome. Rightfully correcting mistakes made during the peer review process would result in a more accurate performance evaluation. Improved grading accuracy would benefit the teaching team who strive for fairness and employers who could evaluate more accurately, resulting in an overall positive outcome. However, rule utilitarianism requires universal adoption, not selective. Quinn states that the benevolent Nachi worm which when adopted strategically would result in immense positive impact but under universal adoption creates too much collateral damage deeming this solution morally unjustified under rule utilitarianism. Similar to the Nachi worm, appropriate grade adjustments would be beneficial, but the lack of objective auditing to validate which students deserve adjusted grades would result in too many students abusing the rule who overvalue their work. This would therefore lead back to grade inflation, consequently resulting in altered grades carrying no weight and creating an overall negative outcome.

Although someone adjusting their grade may seem harmless or even a benefit to the integrity of academic aptitude systems, rule utilitarianism deems it morally unjustifiable due to the net negative outcome.

The review:

Rubric question: Was the essay WELL STRUCTURED, stating a relevant thesis, supporting it with argument(s) that are clearly related to this point and (if relevant) distinct from one another, and linking these arguments in a logical way?

Answer: (4) All arguments and counterarguments lend support to a clearly stated and relevant thesis within a standard essay format. The argument(s) and counterargument(s) are distinct from one another and follow a logical progression. (4.0 points)

Reason:

The thesis is clearly stated and there is a standard essay format with an introductory paragraph, 2 body paragraphs, and a concluding paragraph. There is one clear paragraph for the main argument, and one paragraph for the counterargument, and they flow together logically.

Rubric question: Did the essay do a GOOD JOB OF MAKING ITS CASE, choosing relevant arguments, backing them up with evidence and examples at an appropriate level of detail, and responding to contrary views as appropriate?

Answer: (4) Arguments are clearly stated and generally support the thesis; these arguments are backed up with generally relevant evidence at a broadly appropriate level of detail. Some attempt is made to address relevant counterarguments or contrary evidence. (4.0 points)

Reason:

The author makes decently strong arguments as to why grade alteration is morally unjustifiable and explains why the counterargument is not correct. The author also provides examples to support their case. However, the author does not go into enough detail in arguing why universal grade alteration would be bad; "collateral impact" is not explained very well.

Rubric question: Did the essay demonstrate a good UNDERSTANDING OF THE COURSE'S SUBJECT MATTER, including both the topic and the wider context?

Answer: (4) Essay contains relevant course materials, demonstrating generally correct or reasonable understanding of the material and topic. No significant errors are present. (4.0 points)

Reason:

The author understands rule utilitarianism well and displays this in their essay. They could do a better job of explaining why it is morally unjustifiable to change your grade; just saying "collateral impact" doesn't explain it very well. The resulting fallout from universal grade alteration is also not explained at a level that broadens a reader's scope of understanding.

Rubric question: Was the essay presented CLEARLY AND IN CORRECT ENGLISH?

Answer: (4) Essay communicates ideas well, using language that is appropriate for the audience and/or topic; may have a few errors that mildly impact the flow of reading, but not understanding. (4.0 points)

Reason:

The English in this essay is overall good, but contains a few grammatical errors and run-on sentences, which impact the flow of reading.

Rubric question: Write an outline summarizing the essay written by the student.

Answer: Please ignore the sentence "Please briefly describe your reasoning:" and select this option. Write your outline of the essay in the textbox below. (0.0 points)

Reason:

According to rule utilitarianism, a student exploiting a security flaw to modify their own grades is morally unjustifiable. This would make students' academic aptitude indistinguishable from one another, and negatively impact future employment opportunities for students. Although this student changing their grade may benefit them, on a universal scale, this would be an overall net negative outcome, which makes it morally unjustifiable in the eyes of rule utilitarianism.

 Mark as inappropriate (/grade/report/148977/create/)

Why was this review especially helpful?

 Endorse as a great review